I am not disrespecting those of my Hindu readers who, while fully respecting Husain as an artist, and without expressing any of the communal bigotry that I found particularly distasteful about this affair, nonetheless expressed anguish at seeing representations of goddesses in the nude. They wrote to me at the time of their hurt that images they worshipped should have been so depicted; many asked why Husain has not depicted figures of other faiths, including his own, undressed. (He had once painted the Prophet's wife as a fully clad woman in a sari which even covered her head.) Several added that this was because Hindus are a pushover; other faiths are more robust in their self-defence, whereas Hindus like me are all too willing to accept being insulted.

There's a lot to be said about all this that go beyond the scope of this book. But some points must be made. First: I don't feel insulted by the paintings because (unlike the Danish cartoonists who caricatured the Prophet Muhammad) no insult was intended. Husain was, after all, a major artist, with a long record of being inspired by Hindu mythology as a vital source of inspiration for his work. His paintings of goddesses were consistent with fifty years of his paintings of other iconic Hindu images, clad and unclad. Husain, who grew up in Pandharpur, a major pilgrim centre, and spent all his formative years interacting with devout Hindus, watching Hindu festivals, and drawing nourishment from these influences, was fascinated by Hindu gods. More than the Prophet or any Muslim imagery, what fired his imagination was Hindu India, in which he was reared and which he sought to celebrate. I saw the paintings in that context; his critics saw them out of context (and judging by some emails I received, grossly exaggerated what the paintings depicted). Husain saw his paintings as being within a millennial Indian tradition in which nudity has been widely used in art, including on temple walls. So did I; in Thiruvananthapuram's annual Attukal Bhagavathy festival, the goddess is routinely portrayed topless in posters throughout the city.

Husain as an artist had long used form to suggest ideas beyond form; images in his works are both less and more than realistic depictions of what they portray. His paintings are full of metaphors and allusions; the body, he often said, is a representation of something formless, illusory (a form of *maya*). As a Hindu, I did not see his goddesses as literal